AP schools get low cost educational PCs

Andhra Pradesh has been known to be a progressive state when it comes to implementing latest technology for state welfare. As part of its latest endeavour, the state govt has deployed a massive computerisation project for government schools in just four months.

However, the real feather in the cap is the innovation in technology that has made this possible. The project employs a shared-computing model using NComputing's desktop virtualisation technology. The premise behind the technology is that today's PCs are so powerful that the vast majority of users only use a small fraction of the computer's capacity. Especially, while using it to run simple tasks. In the set up, there are several sets of keyboards, mice and monitors connected to an NComputing device that later connects to a shared PC.

Reports suggest that each one of the students connected, gets full PC experience. Devices are supposed to be easy to install. Moreover, it uses only 1 W of power! The project is currently used to teach students computer skills, office productivity tools such as spreadsheets and word processing, and subjects such as mathematics.

The systems run on the Microsoft Windows Server operating system and uses the Microsoft Office Suite. The project succeeded in facilitating computer access to 1.8 million students across the state, many of whom have probably never even touched a computer. The project is also a success story for the government's new public-private partnership model, where successful partnerships have been formed to achieve transparency, accountability and efficiency.

Microsoft's HR blues

Lately, we've seen some contradictory news coming from Microsoft. Especially in the way they're managing their workforce in these tough times. On one hand, it's facing flack for thinning down their workforce, and on the other more attacks exhorting it to prioritise American workers over foreign guest workers as the software giant downsizes. In the wake of one such a letter by a senator to Microsoft, questions are being asked about the legality of axing H-1B workers.

Microsoft plans to lay off around 5,000 workers, many of whom are H-1B holders. And it appears that it has an affinity for H-1B holders. We're pretty sure any announcement on this front must be sending shivers down the spines of thousands of H-1B holding Indians waiting on the edge of their seats — their fate hanging in the balance. However, some commentators on the subject are claiming that H-1B visas rarely go to exceptional talent and often are used by *body shops* that provide contract labour to other companies.

Another curious incident involves Microsoft asking a refund from the laid-off workers! The software giant, recently laid off 1,400 employees, and has sent letters to some of them saying that their severance payouts were a bit too "generous" and that the employees should pay the money back to Microsoft. Well, the letter at least apologises for any inconvenience caused. Talk about a PR blunder in the making. What could not be found out, however, was the exact amount that was over paid to the employees. Well it must've been quite a significant error really for them to send out such a letter.
To save face with the American public at large, the company is also starting a job training effort aimed at giving technical skills to as many as 2 million Americans over the next three years. The program is being called *Elevate America* and will help people with creating a resume. Elevate America? More like alleviate Microsoft.

Outsourcing wonders of the tech world

When you think of outsourcing what comes to your mind? Probably India and then China. But more specifically Chennai, Shanghai and Mumbai right? Well you can forget about them because the outsourcing hubs of tomorrow will be something like Zagreb and Penang, says a report by KPMG. The first is a city in Malaysia, while the other is in Croatia and several other unheard of places might become the next offshoring mammoths of the world according to the new report which list down 31 such places.

The report indicates that traditional centres are faced with overburdened telecommunications infrastructure and have overstretched labour markets so should be overlooked henceforth. Instead, the report urges companies to look at alternatives it suggests such as cities in the Asia-Pacific region that offer lower costs, younger populations, and government incentives such as easy work permits. While those in Europe, Middle East, and Africa have robust telecommunications and power infrastructures and niche specialisation in fields such as data management. While cities in the Americas can leverage their large pools of labour, a more mature service offering, proximity to major client bases, and multiple language skills.

Atlantis not yet found

Those who have heard of users of Google Earth unearthing Atlantis, Google says its just an artefact of their scanning.

What is curious yet appropriate is that size is not a deciding factor for these emerging cities to be on the list. Cities such as Buenos Aires is home to around 1.3 crore people, while Gdansk in Poland has just 8,00,000 people. The report emphasises on the proportion of computer graduates, the number of research and development institutions, the rate of migration to the cities, and common languages with their target markets. Also, Jaipur and Nagpur featured on the list of 31.

Google tests electricity tracker

The news couldn't have come at a better time. Cost conscious as we all are, we've always fretted about things such as our electricity bills. With the recession eating away everyone's purses and homeowners trying to cut corners in all possible ways, this new service currently being tested by Google, consumers can monitor their home energy usage almost in real time. Environmental concerns are also driving much of the research in this field. It seems there is great demand for products such as this one that track energy usage.

About 40 million trackers are in use worldwide. Google says it believes another 100 million will be sold in the next few years. Google obviously wants to cash in on this opportunity, and is actively testing its own software prototype PowerMeter. These days, you can manage almost anything online, be it your bank account or stock trades. Soon with PowerMeter, you'll be able to manage your power consumption the same way. Simply plug your appliance into the device, specify your electricity cost and it will calculate your bill.

Google PowerMeter will receive information from smart meters and energy management devices and this information will be provided to anyone who signs up access to their home electricity consumption on the iGoogle homepage. Imagine the cost saving that can be brought about by the widespread use of this device. Studies show that such kind of information when made available toconsumers, they'll invariably be able to save 5 to 15 percent on their electricity bills. Google says that for every six households that save 10% on electricity, carbon emissions are reduced to the extent of taking one conventional car off the road.■